raised at the talks and, in fact, faded out of the agenda during subsequent discussions as well. The talks were held in a cordial atmosphere and the Akali leaders were assured by Indira Gandhi that their demands, particularly the religious ones, would be given urgent consideration.' [3]

While the meeting was going on in Delhi, on 16 October Sikh militants attacked Niranjan Singh, an IAS officer of the Punjab cadre, and his brother in the Punjab Government Secretariat complex in Chandigarh. Niranjan Singh escaped with serious injuries but his brother succumbed. On 23 October, Mohinder Pal, a Hindu sarpanch (headman) of Panchta village in Kapurthala district was shot dead. On 14 November, a bomb explosion took place in the office of the DIG, Patiala, the target being DIG D.S. Mangat, who had been sent by Chief Minster Darbara Singh to arrest Bhindranwale from the village of Chando Kalan in Haryana. On 19 November, a police party was attacked in the village of Daheru in Ludhiana district, and one inspector and a constable were killed. This marked the beginning of Bhindranwale targeting policemen or government officials who had in any way stood up to him. [4]

It was in this environment of escalating violence that Indira Gandhi held the second of three rounds of talks with Akali leaders on 26 November 1981 at her Parliament House office. The same Akali leaders who had attended the first round of talks attended this meeting too. In addition to the three senior civil servants who had attended the previous round, External Affairs Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao also attended this meeting. Replying to the demand made by the Akali delegation on 16 October, the PM explained that since pilgrimage cities such as Varanasi and Kurukshetra did not have any formal special status, no such formal recognition could be granted to Amritsar. Regarding the sale of liquor and tobacco in Amritsar, she said that rather than ban them in the whole city, limited area restrictions could be imposed by the local authorities, similar to those in Haridwar and Kurukshetra.

Referring to the demand for live broadcast of kirtan and gurbani from Harmandir Sahib, she said no private party could be given a licence for it, but arrangements could be made through All India Radio (AIR) Jalandhar, for which requisite space in the Golden